
Are You Confused About the Oysterman Turned Democratic Senate Candidate With a Nazi Tattoo? I'm Here to Help.

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Graham Platner, one of the Democrats gunning to oust Republican Susan Collins in Maine's contested senator slot in 2026, had become something of an up-and-coming star in the party for his gruff demeanor, oyster farming, and military background—as well as a Bernie-esque communication style that has rankled some party elders. But over the course of the last week, and especially the past few days, he has been wrapped up in a truly unbelievable suite of scandals. I will now regale you. Strap in, it's about to get ugly.

So, who is Graham Platner? Like, what did we know about him before last week?

Up until about a month ago, he was a pretty anonymous political figure, which I think is instructive of how certain factions of the Democratic Party got themselves into this mess. Basically, Graham Platner is a guy from Maine and a former Marine who completed several combat tours in Iraq and Afghanistan between 2003 and 2016. After wrapping up his combat duties, Platner became an oyster farmer and held a couple of minor community positions around the microscopic town of Sullivan.

Earlier this year, he announced a campaign for the Senate seat currently occupied by Susan Collins—which is one of the very few opportunities Democrats have to gain ground in congress. Platner gained a national profile following a buzzy campaign video accentuating his working-class bona fides, clearly staking out a position on the party's leftward flank. He advocated for socialized health care and child care, and signaled a distaste for America's close relationship with Israel, which made him a favorite among dormant Bernie Bros. Planter has kept the momentum up with magazine profiles and a viral moment at a town hall where he eloquently answered a question about false claims of immigrants getting federal benefits. It seemed like he had a real shot to make noise next year.

You fell for it, didn't you? There's no way you didn't like this guy.

There are some “Man, maybe Platner could be president someday” texts in my phone that I'd like to take back, yes.

So, wait, were there any red flags before all of these controversies started popping up? Anything I should know about?

Not especially. I mean, we did know that in 2018, Platner signed up with Constellis, the former Blackwater—as in, the comically evil private military contractor. That raised some eyebrows, but honestly, we didn't really know much about Platner other than what was orbiting out of his campaign. In retrospect, that might have been strategic on his part.

OK, so what's all this about his Reddit posts?

Right, so, last week a couple of reporters at CNN examined Platner's Reddit history and found a number of posts that rankled the Democratic Party's more conservative constituency. He wrote

about how, as he's gotten older, he's become "a communist," and agreed with another user that all cops are bastards. Frankly I think that kind of language is pretty minor in the grand scheme of things, but whatever. So it goes.

However, in the days that followed, other posts that have popped up in Platner's history have been more damning. In an AskReddit thread about what other users have "always wanted" to ask someone of another race—an insane premise, by the way—Platner wrote, "Why don't black people tip?" (He also made a gross comment about how victims of sexual assault should take some "personal responsibility" in the matter.) For his part, Platner has responded to the fracas by asserting that he was adrift, unmoored, and "fucking around the internet" while making those posts. His campaign went on to release other selections from Platner's Reddit career that paint his presence on the platform in a more sympathetic light. In particular, he has used the platform to advocate that other veterans get mental health assistance from the Department of Veterans Affairs.

I suppose now we have to talk about the Nazi tattoo, right?

You bet we do. I don't really know how to say this, but Graham Platner has a giant *totenkopf* tattooed on his chest. As in, the skull-and-crossbones worn by the SS. Or, in other words, one of the most antisemitic symbols anyone could inflict upon their skin. It is murky how this story broke, exactly. But last night, the *Pod Save America* network posted an interview with Platner—interspersed with the candidate gloriously drunk and shirtless at a wedding, with the *totenkopf* for all to see—which at least *appeared* to be a coordinated attempt to control a looming narrative. (That is at least [what his former political director alleges](#).) Platner's story is that he found himself in Croatia during one of his many combat tours, and, after wandering into a tattoo parlor, elected to get inked with a "terrifying-looking skull and crossbones." Platner claimed to be basically ignorant of the tattoo's greater historical context. And, well ...

I'm going to guess there is a reason to doubt that alibi?

You are correct! Earlier today, [Jewish Insider published a story](#) featuring a former acquaintance of Platner's who recalled the candidate referring to the blotchy skull on his chest as a "totenkopf"—using the precise terminology for, again, one of the most recognizable insignias of Nazi terror. This allegedly happened all the way back in 2012, which, if true, would mean that for a very long time, Platner was aware he had a Nazi tattoo. The man now faces maybe the most damaging and invincible political question of all time, which is: *Why did you not get the giant SS symbol on your chest covered up with literally anything else?*

This whole situation seems unbelievably careless. Like, how did he think this was going to work out for him? He's trying to be a senator, for god's sake.

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Your guess is as good as mine. Even the most charitable reading of the sequence of events—an idiot accidentally signs up for a Nazi tattoo, and celebrates its edginess for years before having a change of heart—is tough to swallow. It's the kind of baggage that poisons every aspect of one's political project. Are you really going to reprimand Trump's fascist leanings with a totenkopf on your chest? Do you really think *you're* the one to advocate for more humane treatment of Palestinians? There is an attitude, among Democrats, that we must be more amenable to voices that don't fit neatly within the confines of the platform. That we need to be less preachy, and administer fewer purity tests. Where do we draw the line of who gets invited into the big tent? I've got an idea. How about we draw the line at Nazi tattoos? I think we can all agree on that.

I still can't believe he wasn't vetted more properly.

Yep, everyone wants an outsider until they show up with a Nazi tattoo. Speaking of which, Platner's flatlining opens the runway for Maine Gov. Janet Mills, who just announced her Senate candidacy, and is turning 78 in two months. We're all going to die!

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